The Fall

Genesis 3 · Romans 5:12–21

The big idea: The world is not the way it was made. Adam and Eve doubted God's word and his goodness, and sin, shame, and death broke into a good world. But in the middle of the judgment, God promised a Rescuer, the woman's offspring, who would crush the serpent's head.

Before you meet: Read

Genesis 3:1–13 | Genesis 3:14–24 | Romans 5:12–21 | Luke 22:39–46

Open (5 minutes)

Where do you see that the world is not the way it should be? What explanations for it have you heard?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Now the serpent was more _____ than any other beast of the field that the LORD God had made." *(Genesis 3:1)*

The serpent told the woman, "You will not surely _____." *(Genesis 3:4)*

Adam said, "The woman whom you _____ to be with me, she gave me fruit of the tree, and I ate." *(Genesis 3:12)*

God said to the serpent about the woman's offspring, "He shall bruise your _____, and you shall bruise his _____." *(Genesis 3:15)*

"And the LORD God made for Adam and for his wife garments of _____ and clothed them." *(Genesis 3:21)*

"For as by the one man's disobedience the many were made sinners, so by the one man's _____ the many will be made righteous." *(Romans 5:19)*

Discuss

1. The serpent questioned God's word, denied his warning, and slandered his heart. Which of those three do you find most tempting? Why? *Genesis 3:1–5*

2. Adam and Eve sewed fig leaves to cover their shame. What fig leaves do people use today to cover what they really are? Which ones do you reach for? *Genesis 3:7*

3. God knew exactly where they were, yet his first words after the fall were a question: "Where are you?" What does that tell you about him? *Genesis 3:8–9*

4. Adam blamed Eve and God. Eve blamed the serpent. Where do you see the blame chain in our world, and in your own life? *Genesis 3:12–13*

5. God spoke the promise of a Rescuer in the middle of the judgment, before he said a word to Adam and Eve about pain and thorns and dust. Why does that matter? *Genesis 3:14–15*

6. Adam acted for all of us, and Christ acts for all who trust him. Why is the idea of a representative both the bad news and the good news? *Romans 5:18–19*

Apply this week

Name your fig leaves. Write down one or two ways you try to cover your sin or shame instead of confessing it, and bring them to God in prayer. When you are tempted this week, ask three questions: Am I doubting God's word? Am I denying the consequences? Am I suspecting God of holding out on me?

Memory verse

"I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and her offspring; he shall bruise your head, and you shall bruise his heel."

Genesis 3:15

Pray

Tell God honestly where you are, the way Adam should have. Confess the fig leaves you hide behind, and thank him that he came looking for you in Jesus, the Offspring who was bruised for you and clothes you in his righteousness.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 4

The Fall

Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Genesis 3 aloud together. Then read Romans 5:12, 18–19.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 1, 5, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Walk through the Turn: Jesus as the Second Adam, tempted in a wilderness, praying in a garden, crowned with thorns, opening paradise to a thief.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 5 (Genesis 4, Genesis 6–9, and Genesis 11:1–9).

Main points to land

1. Temptation works by making us doubt God's word and God's goodness. The serpent questioned, denied, and slandered, and never once said, Disobey (Genesis 3:1–5).
2. Sin brought shame, hiding, and blame. But God came looking: Where are you? He sought sinners before they sought him (Genesis 3:8–9; Luke 19:10).
3. Genesis 3:15 is the first gospel. In the middle of the judgment, God promised a child of the woman who would be wounded and would crush the serpent's head.
4. God covered their shame with garments of skins. Something died so that sinners could be clothed, the first thread of the Lamb (Genesis 3:21).
5. Adam represented us in the covenant of works, and we fell with him: we share his guilt and his corrupted nature. Christ, the Second Adam, represents all who trust him, and his obedience makes them righteous (Romans 5:12, 18–19).

Answer key (Observe)

1. crafty
2. die
3. gave
4. head; heel
5. skins
6. obedience

Questions people will ask

Was there really a talking snake?
Genesis calls the serpent a beast of the field that God had made (3:1), and the curse in 3:14 falls on an animal. From Augustine to Calvin, the church has read it this way: Satan, a fallen angel, spoke through a real creature (Revelation 12:9). Satan still disguises himself as an angel of light (2 Corinthians 11:14). Evil rarely comes looking evil.

Is it fair that Adam's sin counts against me?
Adam had every advantage: an upright nature, a perfect world, one clear command. None of us would have done better. And each of us has added our own sins to his (Romans 5:12). Most of all, the same principle that ruined us in Adam saves us in Christ. If one man could not act for many, one Man could not save many.

If God knew they would fall, why did he put the tree there?
Scripture does not answer every part of this. It does tell us that God is not the author of sin, that Adam chose freely and was responsible, and that God was never caught off guard: the Rescuer was promised the same day. Keep the group on what God did next, not only on what we cannot fully see.

God said they would die that day. Why did they live for years?
They did die that day. They were cut off from the life of God and hiding from him, dead in sin (WCF 6.2; Ephesians 2:1). Their bodies began to wear out toward the grave, which came later (Genesis 3:19; 5:5). Death in the Bible is first separation from God.

Closing prayer

Father, we confess that we have sewn our own fig leaves and pointed our fingers like Adam and Eve. Thank you that you came looking for us, that you promised a Rescuer in the darkest hour, and that you sent your Son, the Second Adam, to be bruised for us and to crush the serpent's head. Clothe us in his righteousness, and draw each one here out of hiding. Amen.